

Patient Faq

Tobacco cessation — patient FAQ

Derived from the WHO *Be He@lthy Be Mobile — mTobaccoCessation handbook*, the QuitNowTXT message library, the *Gambia cessation clinical guidelines* (2016), and the WHO *Framework Convention on Tobacco Control (FCTC) Article 14 guidelines*. Written for people who smoke or chew tobacco and are thinking about quitting, in plain language. Not a substitute for talking to a health worker.

Why quit

Will quitting actually help me, or is the damage already done?

It helps, and surprisingly fast. Within 24 hours of your last cigarette, the carbon monoxide level in your blood drops back to normal. Within a few weeks, your lungs work better and your sense of taste and smell return. Between 2 weeks and 3 months after quitting, your risk of a heart attack already starts to fall. Over years, your risk of stroke, lung cancer and heart disease keeps dropping.

What does smoking actually do to me?

It is the leading cause of preventable death worldwide. Tobacco raises your risk of heart attack, stroke, at least 15 different cancers (lung, mouth, throat, oesophagus, bladder, kidney, pancreas, stomach, cervix, and others), chronic bronchitis, emphysema, infertility, slow wound healing, and gum disease. The only fully safe option is not to smoke at all — there is no such thing as a safe cigarette.

Are hookah, pipes, cigars, or chewing tobacco safer than cigarettes?

No. All forms of tobacco contain nicotine and the same major toxins. Hookah (“shisha”) is often advertised as cleaner because of the water, but a typical session delivers as much smoke as many cigarettes, plus extra carbon monoxide. Smokeless tobacco causes mouth, throat and pancreatic cancer. There is no “safe” form.

What about e-cigarettes (vaping)?

E-cigarettes are not harmless. They are less harmful than cigarettes in the short term, but they are not a recommended way to quit unless your health worker specifically advises them and other options have failed. They keep you addicted to nicotine and the long-term health effects are still being studied.

Getting ready to quit

How do I prepare?

Pick a **Quit Day** within the next 2 weeks — far enough out to plan, near enough that you don’t keep postponing. Between now and then:

1. **Tell a friend or family member.** Quitting alone is much harder.

2. **Identify your triggers** — the times, places, moods and people that make you reach for a cigarette. The first cigarette after waking, the one with tea or coffee, the one after a meal, the one when stressed.
3. **Plan a substitute for each trigger.** A glass of water, a short walk, chewing gum, a few deep breaths, a phone call.
4. **Remove all tobacco from your house, car and bag** before Quit Day. Empty ashtrays, wash clothes that smell of smoke, throw away lighters. If you can see them, you will reach for them.
5. **List your reasons for quitting.** Keep the list in your wallet or on your phone. Re-read it when cravings hit.

How do I pick a Quit Day?

A day with low stress is best. Some people choose a meaningful date (a birthday, a child's birthday, the start of a new month). Others just pick "two weeks from today." Don't pick a holiday or a party day.

Do I have to quit "cold turkey" or can I cut down first?

Both approaches work. Some people find cutting down for a week and then stopping completely on Quit Day works well. Others find that "just one or two" keeps the addiction alive and prefer a clean break. There is no universally better approach — the right one is the one you'll actually follow.

Should I take medication to help?

Medications double your chance of success when used correctly. Three main families are available in many countries:

- **Nicotine replacement therapy (NRT)** — patches, gum, lozenges, inhalers. Available without prescription in many places. Generally safe and the most accessible option.
- **Bupropion** — a prescription tablet that reduces craving.
- **Varenicline** — a prescription tablet that blocks the reward receptor; one of the most effective options where available.

Talk to your health worker about which is appropriate for you, especially if you are pregnant or have a heart condition.

The first week (the hardest)

What does withdrawal feel like?

It varies, but common symptoms in the first 1-2 weeks include:

- Intense cravings (usually short — most cravings last only a few minutes)
- Irritability, anxiety, restlessness
- Difficulty concentrating
- Headaches
- Increased appetite (often for sweet things)
- Trouble sleeping
- Constipation

These are your body adjusting to life without nicotine. They are signs of healing, not damage. They fade within 2-4 weeks.

How do I get through a craving?

The 5-D's: Delay, Deep breath, Drink water, Distract, Discuss.

- **Delay:** A craving feels urgent but it usually passes in 5-10 minutes whether you smoke or not. Set a 5-minute timer.

- **Deep breath:** Breathe in for 4 seconds, hold for 5, breathe out slowly. Repeat several times.
- **Drink water:** Cold water reduces the urge and gives your hands something to hold.
- **Distract:** Stand up, walk, do something with your hands — wash dishes, fold clothes, call a friend.
- **Discuss:** Text the friend who knows you are quitting. Saying it out loud often shrinks the craving.

I keep gaining weight. Help.

Weight gain is common — most people put on 2-5 kg in the first months after quitting, partly because food tastes better and partly because nicotine had been suppressing appetite. To minimise this:

- Keep healthy snacks on hand (fruit, vegetables, plain nuts, sugar-free gum) instead of biscuits and sweets.
- Drink water before meals.
- Walk more — it also dampens cravings.

The cardiovascular benefit of quitting far outweighs the harm of a few extra kilos. Lose the weight later, once the smoke-free habit is solid.

I slipped and had a cigarette. Have I failed?

No. A slip is a single cigarette. A relapse is going back to daily smoking. Most people who eventually quit successfully have several slips along the way. What matters:

1. **Stop now** — don't smoke the rest of the pack.
2. **Identify the trigger** — what set off this slip? Hunger? Stress? A specific situation?
3. **Plan for next time.** What will you do differently when that trigger appears again?
4. **Re-commit.** A slip does not erase the days you've been smoke-free. Keep counting.

Should I avoid coffee and alcohol?

For the first few weeks, yes if you can. Both are strong triggers for many people, and alcohol lowers your defences against impulses. After a month or two of being smoke-free, you can gradually reintroduce coffee. Alcohol around old smoking buddies is one of the most common trigger situations for relapse — be especially careful.

Lifestyle around quitting

What about second-hand smoke at home?

Ask anyone living with you not to smoke indoors or in the car, especially when children are present. Second-hand smoke causes the same cancers and heart disease in non-smokers. If you are quitting and someone in your household keeps smoking near you, your chance of relapse is much higher — have that conversation early.

Will quitting help me even if I'm older or have already had a heart attack?

Yes. There is no age and no condition where quitting stops being worthwhile. After a heart attack, quitting roughly halves the risk of a second event over the following years. The lungs of someone who quits in their 60s still recover useful function.

Will my children copy me?

Children of smokers are more likely to smoke themselves. The single-strongest thing you can do to lower the chance that your children take up tobacco is to quit yourself.

How long until I'm “out of the woods”?

Most relapses happen in the first 3 months. By 6 months smoke-free, your relapse risk drops significantly. By 1 year, you can reasonably call yourself an ex-smoker. Many ex-smokers say cravings can still appear occasionally years later, especially in stressful moments — the trick is having a plan ready.

Money and motivation

How much money will I save?

A rough sum: take what you spend on tobacco per day, multiply by 365. A pack-a-day smoker often saves the price of a smartphone, a year's school fees, or a substantial holiday after just 12 months smoke-free. Some people put the saved amount in a jar daily and use it to reward themselves at milestones.

What benefits will I notice, and when?

- **20 minutes:** pulse rate begins to normalise.
- **12 hours:** carbon monoxide in your blood drops to a normal level.
- **2 weeks - 3 months:** circulation improves, lungs work better, exercise feels easier.
- **1 - 9 months:** less coughing, less shortness of breath, sinuses clear, taste and smell come back.
- **1 year:** your risk of coronary heart disease is half that of a smoker.
- **5 years:** your risk of stroke can fall to that of a non-smoker.
- **10 years:** your risk of dying from lung cancer is about half that of a smoker.

What if I've tried before and failed?

Most successful quitters needed several attempts. Each attempt teaches you something about your triggers and what kind of support you need. The right framing isn't “I failed”, it's “I'm getting closer.”